Junior Klegseth
All rights reserved

Wagner's Cycle

Half-life

He didn't know his father, who left when he was five. He knows his father took him to the bar, sometimes burned him with cigarettes and left him lying on the musty couch in some woman's house while his father and the woman had sex in the next room, on the floor, or on the chaise lounge. His mother likes to remind him that three men in his family died at the age of thirty-six (goddamned poetic justice, that). Visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the sons, she tells him, and in a chilled-molasses drawl goes on to say his expiry date is drawing near. He counters, if never verbally, that surely there must be a dispensation if said sins were committed on the inheritor. After all, can he be both sinner and sinnee? He doesn't remember being that child. Neither do I. Lately, memories come randomly, like crippled helium balloons careening back to earth. We are vaguely aware of each other but unable to exchange consolations, like children trapped in cars parked side-by-side, staring out the windows, the heat rising.

HEMI

The heat rising from the hood in vapors unsteadied the horizon. A 1969 Plymouth Road Runner HEMI, burnt orange with a black vinyl top, persimmon rims and chrome hubcaps, 426-cubic-inches, 425 horsepower, 0 to 60 in 5.1 seconds, quarter mile in 13.54, a Jensen stereo and coaxial speakers. "How fast can it go?" you always asked. "How fast?" But what you really wanted to ask was, "How fast can you get me away?" He was a patient inquisitor who thought you liked the bawling engine, the nauseous turbine in your gut, the wind that forced random vowels and

consonants into your open mouth. It took many rides before you found you were marked for life, before you found that speed only matters in calculating A → B, not A → A.

Hemisphere

A → A! That's what the muted yellow decal on the metal lathe at the factory screams, as if even that is too much for you to infer. After work, at the bar, the guys still ply the tired gag when you leave. "Driving home to the *cul-de-sac*?" they call out, almost by rote, followed by random laughter. You've long since quit countering that it is a dead end. You've long since quit countering that it is dead. You've long since quit countering that it is. You've long since quit countering. You've long since quit.

Carbon Dating

Quit before the quarrel breaks out, for the beginning of strife is like letting out water. So many I's and you's and she's and he's and they's and we's and us's and them's nouns adjectives adverbs pronouns verbs→regular and irregular→active tense, passive tense, present, past, and future tense, and the false prophets→simple past, past perfect, simple future, future perfect→apostasies all, useless in the random trials of the Inquisition. And as the heretic, abandoned by vowels consonants and future perfect, is carted on rough-hewn wooden wheels to meet Fate, something passes the lips on anemic breath. It is, simply this: He didn't know his father, who left when he was five.